and so the practice has now been stopped. Thousands upon thousands of people would flock to Goa on the occasion. The inflow of traffic from neighbouring Karnataka would be almost non-stop. Such an influx would certainly put immense pressure on the road traffic, especially around the church area. The worst affected were naturally the pedestrians, of whom countless numbers suffered physical injuries by being scruffed by the cars that insisted on driving right up to the cathedral gate. The traffic too remained blocked for days together.

On the occasion of the Exposition, the scanty Goa traffic police would be bolstered by a few 'imports' from the Karnataka traffic police. But the purpose of this bolstering was clearly that the police should ensure that the VIPs' cars reached the cathedral gates without a hitch. 'VIPs never got to see the chaos. The police are content with saluting their bosses and giving them special right of way. VIPs considered this privilege their right, the police their duty and the people their destiny,' explains Kiran.

But this time things were *not* going to be the same. It was going to be the people's turn to avail of their right for a safe, obstruction-free pedestrian passage and parking space with uniformed men to regulate the flow of traffic and the crowds. The VIPs were to be given a nearby parking lot from where they would have to walk to the gate. This would eliminate the problems the pedestrians faced due to the VIPs' and police vehicles. The people loved the arrangement but the VIPs resented it. As Kiran puts it: 'The people appreciated it but the VIPs called for my apologies and explanations.'

One of the senior ministers of the Goa cabinet visited the cathedral. His car was stopped at the parking lot meant for VIPs and he was requested to walk the remaining few yards to the cathedral gate. This was never heard of in the Goa VIP circles and the matter was taken up with Chief Minister Pratapsingh Rane.

Kiran was summoned to the CM's office and asked to tender an apology to the concerned minister.

She replied: 'Is the honourable minister not well, Sir?'

'The minister has the honour to drive to the gate. You must correct your traffic arrangements.'

'You may be aware, Sir, of the people's appreciation for this arrangement?' Kiran had the courage to ask the CM.

'Never mind the public. Ministers must be allowed to drive right up to the gate,' he insisted.

'But that would mean having no traffic arrangements at all.'

'Who made these arrangements?'

'I did, Sir.'

'Did the IGP [inspector general of police] approve of them?'

'Yes, Sir.'

'Then I will speak to him. I shall tell him to change the arrangements.'

'You may do so, Sir. But then may I request to be relieved of traffic duties.'

'We'll see about that,' said the CM, ending the meeting.

The CM, it appears, never spoke to the IGP. The public was extremely appreciative of the relief its members got. They could park their vehicles properly, walk to the church and return in an orderly way. They could pull out their vehicles without waiting for hours for others to give way. The police were there for them. But this was not the way the ministers wanted things to be. They perhaps never forgave Kiran for treating them as equals!

But there were others who were treated as equally important and who would never forget the November of 1983. That was the time when the Commonwealth Heads of Government Meet (CHOGM) was being held in Goa. This was a great event for the region. A number of benefits that would have taken years to materialize came instantly: Total lighting of the new airport road; an